10th Class English • Unit 5 • Punjab Board (New Syllabus 2026)

The Happy Prince — Oscar Wilde

Fully solved exercises: comprehension, MCQs, glossary, parts of speech, elevated vocabulary, rhetorical questions, sensory language and setting

A. The Story at a Glance

Writer: Oscar Wilde. **Type:** a fairy tale / short story with a moral, written in simple, poetic and tender prose. **Characters:** the statue of the Happy Prince, the little Swallow, the poor seamstress and her sick son, the young writer in the garret, the match-girl, the Town Councillors, the Mayor and God's angel. **Setting:** a European city with a cathedral, a palace, a river and a market square; the statue stands on a tall column high above the city.

Part of the plot	What happens
Beginning	The gilded statue of the Happy Prince, with sapphire eyes and a ruby on his sword-hilt, stands high above the city. In life he lived in the Sans-Souci Palace of pleasure and never knew sorrow. A little Swallow on his way to Egypt takes shelter between the statue's feet and is wetted by the Prince's tears.
The three gifts	The Prince sends the Swallow with his **ruby** to the poor seamstress whose son is ill with fever, with one **sapphire eye** to the poor writer in the garret, and with the other **sapphire** to the little match-girl whose matches fell in the gutter.
The gold	Now blind, the Prince asks the Swallow to peel off his gold leaf by leaf and give it to the poor. The city's children grow rosy and happy; the statue becomes dull and grey.
Winter and the end	The Swallow refuses to leave the blind Prince and stays with him in the snow. He dies at the Prince's feet, and the leaden heart of the statue breaks in two. The Councillors pull the statue down and melt it, but the heart will not melt, and it is thrown on the dust-heap beside the dead bird.
God's angel	The angel carries “the two most precious things in the city” — the lead heart and the dead Swallow — and God says they will sing in His city of gold forever.

Themes: compassion and service; sacrifice; the difference between outward beauty and inner worth; the blindness of the rich to the suffering of the poor; true happiness found in giving.

B. Reading Comprehension — Answer the following questions

1. Why is the statue of the Happy Prince crying, even though he was known as “Happy Prince” during his life?

In his life the Prince lived in the Sans-Souci Palace, behind high walls, where sorrow was not allowed to enter; he was called happy because he had never seen unhappiness. Now, as a statue standing high above the city, he can see every street and every house. He sees the poor seamstress with pricked fingers and a sick son, the young writer starving in a cold garret and the little match-girl crying in the rain. This misery makes his eyes fill with tears which trickle down his golden cheeks. So he weeps not because he has lost anything, but because he has finally learned what suffering is; his old happiness was only ignorance.

2. What motivates the Swallow to delay his journey to Egypt and help the Happy Prince?

In the beginning the Swallow stays only because the Prince's tears fall on him and he is sorry for the statue. He is then moved by the Prince's kindness: the Prince gives away his own ruby, his eyes and his gold, and the bird sees that this is true love. Gratitude, pity and admiration turn into friendship and then into love, so each time he says “tomorrow I will go to Egypt” and each time stays one more night. When the Prince becomes blind he decides never to leave him, and finally he dies at his feet. His motive, in one word, is love.

3. Describe the first act of kindness that the Happy Prince and the Swallow performed together.

The Prince told the Swallow about a poor seamstress in a little street whose son was ill with fever and was asking for oranges, while the mother had nothing to give him except river water. The Prince could not move, so the Swallow took the great ruby out of the statue's sword-hilt and flew with it to her house. He laid the ruby on the sewing-table and then flew round the sick child's bed, fanning his forehead with his wings. The boy fell into a cool, sweet sleep as the fever left him, and the Swallow returned to tell the Prince, feeling warm although the night was cold.

4. How does the relationship between the Happy Prince and the Swallow change throughout the story?

It changes in four clear stages. **First**, they are strangers: the Swallow is only looking for a dry place to sleep and is surprised by the falling tears. **Second**, they become a master and a willing messenger, as the bird carries the ruby and the sapphires. **Third**, they become friends and companions: the bird refuses to go to Egypt, warms the Prince's heart with stories of foreign lands and finally decides to stay because the Prince cannot see. **Fourth**, the relationship becomes one of total sacrifice and love — the bird dies at the Prince's feet and the Prince's leaden heart breaks in two. In the end they are inseparable, and they are rewarded together by God.

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5. What does the Prince mean when he says, “There is no Mystery so great as Misery”?

He means that suffering is the deepest mystery of human life. A man can explain where the stars are or how gold is made, but nobody can explain satisfactorily why a child should be born in a slum, or why a mother should have nothing to give her sick son. He also means that misery is hidden from those who live in comfort: he himself lived for years in a palace and never knew it. So the sentence is the voice of his new compassion — he is saying that the greatest mystery is not beauty but sorrow, and the greatest duty is to relieve it.

6. Why does the Prince ask the Swallow to strip off his gold leaf by leaf? What effect does this have on the people of the city?

The Prince asks for the gold to be taken leaf by leaf because gold is only beautiful and useless on a statue, but as money it can become bread, firewood and medicine. Once he is blind he can no longer see the misery, but he knows it is there, so he gives the last thing he owns. The effect is great: the poor children get food and grow rosy and happy, they laugh and play in the streets, and the town looks less ugly and cold. The statue itself becomes dull and grey, but the city is warmer.

7. What message do you think Oscar Wilde is trying to convey about wealth, beauty and true value?

Wilde's message is that wealth and outward beauty have no value until they are turned into kindness. The statue is admired for its gold and jewels, but it becomes truly beautiful only when it gives all of them away. The Councillors and the Mayor judge only by appearance — they call the statue beautiful while it is golden and throw it away when it is dull, and they call themselves respectable while ignoring the poor. By contrast, the lead heart and the dead Swallow, which the city rejects as rubbish, are named by God's angel as the two most precious things in the city. So true value lies in love and sacrifice, not in gold, and it is often invisible to the world.

8. What is the symbolic meaning of the Swallow dying at the Prince's feet and the leaden heart not melting in the furnace?

The Swallow dying at the Prince's feet symbolises complete sacrifice: love that goes on to the very last breath and refuses to save itself. It also shows that the Prince's good deeds were not done by magic; somebody had to pay for them, and the little bird paid with his life. The leaden heart that will not melt in the furnace symbolises the immortality of a loving heart: the furnace is made to melt metal, but it cannot melt love, goodness or memory. The world may destroy the body and the gold, but it cannot destroy the value of what was done, and God's angel proves this by choosing the heart and the bird as the city's two most precious things.

C. Choose the Correct Option (MCQs) — solved with key

1. Where did the Happy Prince live before becoming a statue?

King's Palace
Royal Garden
Sans-Souci Palace
Queen's Castle

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Answer: Sans-Souci Palace — He lived in the palace of Sans-Souci, where sorrow was not allowed to enter.

2. Where did the Swallow want to migrate before meeting the Prince?

South America Eastern Asia
Nile Valley Egypt

Answer: Egypt — His friends had gone to Egypt six weeks before, and he was on his way there.

3. What did the Happy Prince give to the poor seamstress?

golden feather ruby jewel
silver ring crystal bead

Answer: ruby jewel — The great ruby was taken from the sword-hilt of the statue.

4. What were the eyes of the Happy Prince made of?

white pearls shiny glass
blue diamonds rare sapphires

Answer: rare sapphires — The story says he had “two bright sapphires” for eyes.

5. What did the Mayor decide to do with the statue in the end?

paint again remove the statue
rebuild it burn it

Answer: remove the statue — The statue was pulled down because it was “not useful” any more.

6. What happened to the Happy Prince's heart at the end?

melted completely turned black
broke apart vanished instantly

Answer: broke apart — The leaden heart cracked in two when the Swallow died.

7. What did the Swallow do with the gold leaves?

buried them gave them away
ate them up sold them

Answer: gave them away — He carried the gold leaf by leaf to the poor houses of the city.

8. What was thrown onto the dust-heap together in the end?

bird bones lead heart
gold dust silver wings

Answer: lead heart — The lead heart was thrown on the dust-heap beside the dead Swallow.

D. Glossary — Words and Meanings

Word	Meaning
agility	the ability to move quickly and easily

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Word	Meaning
alighted	landed or came down gently from the air
coarse	rough or harsh in texture; not smooth
determined	having made a firm decision and not changing it
drenched	completely wet or soaked
flapping	moving or beating the wings quickly
furnace	an enclosed structure used for heating or melting things
gilded	covered with a thin layer of gold
grate	a metal frame in a fireplace that holds the burning fuel
hauling	pulling or dragging something with effort or force
melted	changed from solid to liquid due to heat
Ornithology	the scientific study of birds
pleasure	a feeling of happiness or enjoyment
sensible	showing good judgment; practical and reasonable
slumber	a peaceful or deep sleep
spoiled	damaged, ruined or no longer usable
starving	suffering or dying from extreme hunger

E. Vocabulary and Grammar — Parts of Speech

Words are divided into eight **parts of speech** according to the work they do in a sentence. The same word can change its part of speech when its work changes.

Part of speech	Work in the sentence	Example
Noun	Names a person, place, thing or idea	“Prince”, “money”, “kindness”
Pronoun	Replaces a noun	“he”, “it”, “they”
Verb	Shows action or state of being	“gave”, “shone”, “is”
Adjective	Describes a noun or pronoun	“kind”, “poor”, “fine”
Adverb	Modifies a verb, an adjective or another adverb	“quickly”, “gently”, “far”
Preposition	Shows relationship of a noun with another word	“on”, “under”, “through”
Conjunction	Joins words or groups of words	“and”, “but”, “so”

Part of speech	Work in the sentence	Example
Interjection	Expresses sudden emotion	“Ah!”, “Oh!”

Learn one example from the story for each part of speech — the paper often asks for identification from a given sentence.

Task 1: rewrite the ending using at least five parts of speech

“The grey statue stood alone in the cold square. Suddenly, an angel came down through the dark sky and gently lifted the little dead bird and the broken lead heart, because God had called them His two most precious things. Ah! what a beautiful reward for a small, kind life!”

Part of speech	Words used in the rewritten ending
Noun	statue, square, angel, sky, bird, heart, God, things, life
Pronoun	them, His
Verb	stood, came, lifted, had called
Adjective	grey, cold, little, dead, broken, precious, beautiful, small, kind
Adverb	alone, suddenly, gently
Preposition	in, down, through, for
Conjunction	and, because
Interjection	Ah!

Task 2: three examples of interesting or elevated vocabulary

Word	Meaning	Why it is effective
gilded	covered with a thin layer of gold	One word paints the whole statue as golden and shining, and it suggests that the beauty is only a thin skin.
slumber	a peaceful, deep sleep	A softer and more poetic word than “sleep”; it suits the fairy-tale tone of the story.
alighted	came down gently from the air	It describes a bird's landing gracefully, better than the plain word “landed”.

F. Oral Communication Skills — Rhetorical Questions

A **rhetorical question** is a question asked not to receive an answer but to make a point, emphasise an idea or persuade the listener. The answer is obvious or already known, and the question makes the reader think. In the story, the Swallow's “Why are you weeping then?” is rhetorical: it stresses the shocking contrast between the name “Happy” and the statue's tears.

1. Rhetorical questions for a speech on donating to the poor

(i) “If we can spend thousands of rupees on one wedding dinner, can we not spare a hundred for a child who has not eaten for two days?”

(ii) “When a hungry child stands at our gate, is he not our own child?”

2. Rhetorical questions for a blog post on the kindness of people

(i) “Have you ever noticed how one small act of kindness can change a stranger's whole day?”

(ii) “If a rickshaw driver can return a lost wallet with a smile, what excuse do the rest of us have?”

3. Discussion: do rhetorical questions make writing more powerful or just more poetic?

Group A (more powerful): a rhetorical question pulls the reader into the text, because his own mind must answer it. In a speech it creates a pause and forces the audience to agree, and in an argument it makes the opponent's position look weak without a single rude word. Powerful speeches and essays of every age use it, so it is a tool of persuasion, not decoration.

Group B (only more poetic): if a writer asks question after question and gives no facts, the writing sounds like a slogan or an advertisement. Readers stop trusting it, because a question is not evidence. Overused, it becomes rhythm without reason.

Conclusion of the class: a rhetorical question is powerful when it comes after proof and is used sparingly — one or two in a whole speech. Used as a substitute for argument, it is only poetic noise.

G. Writing Skills — Sensory Language and Setting

A. How does Oscar Wilde use sensory language to show the sadness of the Happy Prince?

Wilde makes us see and feel the Prince's grief instead of merely naming it. He appeals to **sight** with “his eyes filled with tears, and they trickled down his golden cheeks”; to **touch** with the “large drop of water” that falls on the sleeping Swallow, so that we feel the tear before we understand it; and to **sound** with his “low, musical voice” and with the little bird's questioning cries. The contrast between the shining gold and the falling tears makes the sorrow sharper, and the fact that a statue — cold metal and stone — should weep is itself the strongest picture of sadness.

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B. Which details help you imagine the setting where the Swallow finds shelter beneath the statue?

The story gives a clear picture: the statue stands “high above the city, on a tall column”; it is gilded all over with thin leaves of fine gold, has two bright sapphires for eyes and a large red ruby glowing on its sword-hilt. The Swallow calls the space between the feet “a golden bedroom” and notices “plenty of fresh air” and no cloud in the sky. Around them are the cathedral tower, the river, the palace and the poor little street below, and later the snow, the frost and the long icicles “like crystal daggers”. These details of gold, height, cold and darkness make the shelter both beautiful and lonely.

C. Identify a sentence that appeals to your senses (sight, sound, touch, etc.) in the story.

“The streets looked as if they were made of silver… long icicles hung down from the eaves like crystal daggers.” This sentence appeals to **sight** (silver streets, crystal daggers) and to **touch** (bitter cold, hard ice). Another good example is “a large drop of water fell on him”, which appeals to touch, and “the sparrows chirped”, which appeals to sound.

D. What effect do the author's descriptive words and details have on the reader's understanding of the Prince's character and emotions?

The descriptive words make the Prince's goodness believable, because we watch it happen step by step: the ruby leaves the sword-hilt, then one sapphire eye, then the other, and at last the gold is peeled off leaf by leaf. Each loss is described in a physical detail — the dull, grey face, the blindness, the cracked leaden heart — so the reader feels the cost of his kindness. Words like “glowed”, “bright” and “fine” create beauty at the start, and “dull”, “grey” and “broken” create pity at the end; this contrast teaches us that his outer beauty was only a sign of the inner goodness, which keeps increasing as the gold decreases.

H. Summary and Message of the Story

A gilded statue of a prince stands high above a city on a tall column. In his life the Happy Prince lived in the Sans-Souci Palace and never knew sorrow; now, from his column, he sees all the misery of the poor and weeps. A little Swallow, on his way to Egypt, shelters between the statue's feet and becomes his messenger: he carries the ruby to a poor seamstress with a sick son, one sapphire eye to a starving young writer, and the other sapphire to a little match-girl. Then, at the Prince's wish, he peels off the gold leaf by leaf and gives it to the poor, and the children of the city grow healthy and happy while the statue turns dull and grey. When winter comes the Swallow refuses to leave the blind Prince and dies at his feet, and the Prince's leaden heart breaks in two. The Councillors pull the statue down and melt it, but the heart will not melt and is thrown on the dust-heap beside the dead bird. An angel carries the heart and the Swallow to God as the two most precious things in the city. The story teaches that wealth and beauty have no value until they are given away in love, and that kindness and sacrifice are the real treasures, even when the world

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does not recognise them.

Points to Remember

• Writer: Oscar Wilde; a fairy tale with a moral; themes of compassion, sacrifice and true value.

• Where he lived: Sans-Souci Palace. Eyes: sapphires. Sword-hilt: a great ruby. Body: thin leaves of fine gold.

• Three gifts: ruby → seamstress; first sapphire → young writer; second sapphire → match-girl; then all the gold → the poor.

• Swallow's destination: Egypt (his friends had gone six weeks earlier).

• End: the Swallow dies at the Prince's feet; the leaden heart breaks in two and will not melt in the furnace.

• God's angel takes "the two most precious things" — the lead heart and the dead Swallow.

• Key quotation: "There is no Mystery so great as Misery."

• Eight parts of speech: noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection.

• Rhetorical question = a question asked to make a point, not to get an answer.

• Glossary: agility, alighted, coarse, determined, drenched, flapping, furnace, gilded, grate, hauling, melted, ornithology, pleasure, sensible, slumber, spoiled, starving.

Study